We bowl dry. I have learned over time to be able to bowl the same area again and again, tiny variations on the theme keeping batters guessing. Unrelenting. As packs, we pride ourselves on getting out of spells clean, not giving up cheap runs by trying to bowl a magic ball at the end of your spell, so that the pressure you have created on a batter is inherited by the next and then handed down to the next bowler. It's all about packs and a well-worn sense of trust, respect and attrition. So, despite losing the second Test and going in at 1-1, when we walk out of that darkness at the MCG towards the light opening out from the dressing room and feel the banging reverberating around the underbelly of the ground, we are not looking 360 degrees up and around at the surroundings. There's a tighter focus, a sense of collective purpose and belief that was not there when I made my debut here, nor for the last Ashes when the wheels came off by Christmas.

Strauss wins the toss and bowls first. I am opening the bowling, the first to take the ball. Before I run in to bowl the first ball, I register how succinctly everything now seems to fit. It's not like that first time here, when my shirt bore no name, Bay 13 constantly screaming at me and everything hanging off me like a clothes hanger. I don't even feel smaller than the space. I'm just calm and confident inside the most intense, hostile cricket ground imaginable. I'm a father of two now, a young family watching at home in the middle of the night. This is just a game.

There is plenty assisting us to begin with, but my luck is out. Paul Collingwood drops a difficult chance, then Kevin Pietersen an easier one. I think I've got Phil Hughes too before a review shows the ball has clipped his shirt rather than his bat. But there is no inner sense of injustice, of a moment forever gone. It all just feels like it's going to happen, like we are too good for it not to. I am taken off and Chris Tremlett does the early damage. Shane Watson is caught on the crease, fending at a ball that jumps at him, edging it to Kevin Pietersen, who takes the catch safely. Phil Hughes then has a go at Bresnan – not getting all of a big square drive and just finding Pietersen again, this time Kevin's legs bent and receiving a quicker one with equal grace. Tremlett gets an out-of-sorts Ricky Ponting next, bowling an unplayable one that asks a batter to judge the unjudgeable, to question whether a ball can be left alone or needs to be defended. He nicks it behind to Graeme Swann, off the shoulder of the bat, trying